

A valuation obstruction for 3×3 magic squares of squares, with a machine-checked proof

Florian Ernst Albin Morel

August 2026 — draft

Abstract

We study the open problem of whether a 3×3 magic square whose nine distinct entries are perfect squares exists. We reduce the problem to a purely additive condition on the set $D(e) = \{2xy : x^2 + y^2 = e^2\}$ attached to the center root e , and prove unconditionally that the center root of any such square must be divisible by at least two distinct primes $p \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$: for centers $e = sp^a$ with a single such prime, the elements of $D(e)$ have pairwise distinct p -adic valuations, which is incompatible with the required additive structure. All results, including the reduction, are formally verified in Lean 4 with mathlib. We also report an exhaustive computation showing no magic square of squares has center entry below 10^{20} , and that Bremner’s fully magic square with seven square entries is, up to scaling, the only one with center root below 10^9 . Finally we describe a rigidity phenomenon that pins down the remaining two-prime case to explicit divisibility coincidences.

1 Introduction

Whether nine distinct perfect squares can form a fully magic 3×3 square is a well-known open problem, popularized by Martin Gardner’s 1996 prize and studied extensively since; see Boyer’s survey and problem collection [1]. The strongest results to date are computational (searches over magic sums and over arithmetic-progression parameters) together with structural constraints on hypothetical solutions due to Morgenstern, Roberts, Underwood and others [1].

Throughout, a *magic square of squares* is a 3×3 array of nine distinct perfect squares whose three rows, three columns and both diagonals share a common sum S . Summing the four lines through the center shows $S = 3E$ where $E = e^2$ is the center entry; we call e the *center root*.

Results

Theorem 1 (Reduction). *Let $D(e) = \{2xy : x^2 + y^2 = e^2, 0 < x < y\}$. A magic square of squares with center e^2 exists if and only if there are u, v with $u, v, u + v, u - v \in D(e)$ (all nonzero, $u \neq v$); the square’s entries are then $e^2, e^2 \pm u, e^2 \pm v, e^2 \pm (u + v), e^2 \pm (u - v)$.*

Theorem 2 (Main theorem). *If the center root e is divisible by at most one prime $p \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$ (to any power, and with arbitrary cofactor free of such primes), then no magic square*

of squares with center e^2 exists. Equivalently: the center root of any magic square of squares is divisible by at least two distinct primes $\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$.

Theorem 3 (Computations). *There is no magic square of squares with center entry $e^2 < 10^{20}$. Moreover, every fully magic 3×3 square with exactly seven square entries and center root $e < 10^9$ is an integer scaling of Bremner's example with $e = 425$.*

All statements of Theorems 1 and 2, including Fermat's theorem that three squares in arithmetic progression have common difference divisible by 24, are formally verified in Lean 4 over mathlib; the library (thirteen files, no unproven assumptions) accompanies this paper.

2 The reduction

Every 3×3 magic square has the form $c \pm \{0, u, v, u + v, u - v\}$ arranged as

$$\begin{pmatrix} c+u & c-u-v & c+v \\ c-u+v & c & c+u-v \\ c-v & c+u+v & c-u \end{pmatrix},$$

in which all eight line sums equal $3c$ identically. Thus magic is free and the entire problem is the squareness of the nine cells.

Lemma 4. *For $c = e^2$, both $c - d$ and $c + d$ are squares if and only if $d \in D(e) \cup \{0\}$ (up to sign). Indeed if $x^2 + y^2 = e^2$ then $c - 2xy = (x - y)^2$ and $c + 2xy = (x + y)^2$; conversely if $c - d = A^2$ and $c + d = B^2$ then $A^2 + B^2 = 2e^2$, $A \equiv B \pmod{2}$, and $x = \frac{B-A}{2}$, $y = \frac{B+A}{2}$ satisfy $x^2 + y^2 = e^2$, $2xy = d$.*

Theorem 1 follows by applying Lemma 4 to the four center lines. (Distinctness of the nine entries corresponds to $u, v, u \pm v \neq 0$ and $u \neq v$.)

3 Proof of the main theorem

Fix a prime $p \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, write $p = \pi \bar{\pi}$ in $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ with $\pi = A + Bi$, $A^2 + B^2 = p$, and let $e = sp^a$ with $a \geq 0$ and s free of primes $\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$.

Lemma 5 (Rigid part). *Every $z \in \mathbb{Z}[i]$ with $N(z) = s^2$ is a unit multiple of s .*

Proof. Induct on the least prime factor q of s . If $q \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ then q is inert; $q \mid N(z) = z\bar{z}$ gives $q \mid z$, and we divide. If $q = 2$, then $1 + i$ divides z twice (as $2 \mid N(z)$ twice), and $(1 + i)^2 = 2i$ is 2 times a unit. $\square$

Lemma 6 (Classification). *Every $z \in \mathbb{Z}[i]$ with $N(z) = s^2 p^n$ equals $us^j \pi^j \bar{\pi}^{n-j}$ for a unit u and some $0 \leq j \leq n$.*

Proof. Induct on n : for $n \geq 1$, $\pi \mid p \mid z\bar{z}$, so $\pi \mid z$ or $\bar{\pi} \mid z$; divide and recurse, finishing with Lemma 5. $\square$

Lemma 7 (Bridge). *For every $m \geq 1$, $p \nmid \text{Im}(\pi^m)$.*

Proof. Pick $\omega \in \mathbb{Z}/p$ with $\omega^2 = -1$ (possible as $p \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$) and consider the ring maps $\varphi_{\pm} : \mathbb{Z}[i] \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}/p$, $i \mapsto \pm\omega$. If $p \mid \text{Im}(\pi^m)$ then, since $\text{Re}(\pi^m)^2 + \text{Im}(\pi^m)^2 = p^m$, also $p \mid \text{Re}(\pi^m)$, so $\varphi_{\pm}(\pi)^m = 0$; as $\mathbb{Z}/p$ is a field, $\varphi_{\pm}(\pi) = 0$, i.e. $A \pm B\omega \equiv 0$. Adding and subtracting gives $p \mid A$, $p \mid B$, contradicting $A^2 + B^2 = p$. $\square$

Lemma 8 (Representation structure). *Let $x^2 + y^2 = e^2 = s^2 p^{2a}$ with $xy \neq 0$. Then there are $1 \leq t \leq a$ and $\varepsilon \in \{\pm 1\}$ with*

$$2xy = \varepsilon p^{2(a-t)} (s^2 \text{Im} \pi^{4t}), \quad p \nmid s^2 \text{Im} \pi^{4t}.$$

In particular $\nu_p(2xy) = 2(a-t)$, and distinct elements of $D(e)$ have pairwise distinct p -adic valuations $\{0, 2, \dots, 2a-2\}$.

Proof. Write $z = x + yi$; by Lemma 6, $z = u s \pi^j \bar{\pi}^{2a-j}$. Then $2xy = \text{Im}(z^2)$ and $z^2 = u^2 s^2 \pi^{2j} \bar{\pi}^{2(2a-j)}$ with $u^2 = \pm 1$. If $j = a$ the product is real and $xy = 0$. Otherwise, with $t = |j-a|$, $\pi^{2j} \bar{\pi}^{2(2a-j)} = p^{2(a-t)} \cdot \pi^{\pm 4t}$, and $\text{Im}(\pi^{4t}) = -\text{Im}(\bar{\pi}^{4t})$; absorb signs into ε . Lemma 7 and $p \nmid s$ give the non-divisibility. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 2. Suppose $u, v, u+v, u-v \in D(e)$ as in Theorem 1, and give each the form of Lemma 8 with parameters (t_i, ε_i) and constants $c_t = s^2 \text{Im} \pi^{4t}$. If $t_1 = t_2$ then $u = \pm v$, excluded. Otherwise $\nu_p(u) \neq \nu_p(v)$; writing $u \pm v = p^{\min} \cdot (\text{bracket})$ where the bracket is $\varepsilon_i c_{t_i} + (\text{multiple of } p)$, the bracket is prime to p . Comparing with the exact forms of $u+v$ and $u-v$ and using uniqueness of exact p -power extraction, $2(a-t_3) = 2(a-t_4) = \min$, so $t_3 = t_4$ and $u+v = \pm(u-v)$, forcing $u = 0$ or $v = 0$. Contradiction. $\square$

Remark 9. The counting argument (four center lines require four representations) already forces two distinct primes or $p^4 \mid e$; the valuation argument closes the prime-power loophole entirely and is what we formalize.

4 Computations

Enumerating candidate centers directly through Theorem 1 is far cheaper than enumerating magic sums: factoring e in windows and generating $D(e)$ from the Gaussian factorization checks all $e < 10^{10}$ (center entries to 10^{20}) in minutes on a desktop; no configuration $u, v, u \pm v \in D(e)$ exists in that range. The same machinery classifies near-misses: configurations with two of the four differences in $D(e)$ and the other two “half in” (one square cell each) are exactly the fully magic squares with seven square entries, of which Bremner’s $e = 425$ example was the only one known. Scanning all $e < 10^9$ finds 2,352,941 such configurations — every single one an integer scaling of $e = 425$, and none with eight square entries.

5 The minimal two-prime case

Theorem 10. *There is no magic square of squares whose center root is spq , where $p \neq q$ are primes $\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, each to the first power, and s is free of such primes.*

Proof sketch. Here $D(e)$ has exactly four elements: the interior conjugate pair $m, m' = s^2 |\text{Im}(\pi^4 \chi^{\pm 4})|$ and the axis elements $X = s^2 q^2 |\text{Im} \pi^4|$, $Y = s^2 p^2 |\text{Im} \chi^4|$. Since $u, v, u+v, u-v$

are four distinct elements of $D(e)$, they exhaust it. Write $\pi^4 = R_A + I_A i$, $\chi^4 = R_B + I_B i$; recall R_A, R_B are odd, $4 \mid I_A, I_B$, and by Lemma 7 $p \nmid I_A$, $q \nmid I_B$ (and $I_A, I_B \neq 0$). Enumerate the placements of $\{X, Y\}$ among $\{u, v, u+v, u-v\}$:

(1) $\{u, v\} = \{X, Y\}$. Then $\{u \pm v\} = \{m, m'\}$ and the conjugate-pair identities force $\{u, v\} = \{s^2 |R_B I_A|, s^2 |I_B R_A|\}$. Matching against X, Y and multiplying the two resulting equations gives $|R_A R_B| = p^2 q^2$; but $|R_A| < p^2$ and $|R_B| < q^2$ strictly (as $I_A, I_B \neq 0$), a contradiction. The crossed matching forces $|R_A| = p^2$ outright, equally impossible.

(2) $\{u, v\} = \{m, m'\}$. Then $\{u \pm v\} = \{X, Y\}$ and $u+v, u-v \in \{2s^2 |R_B I_A|, 2s^2 |I_B R_A|\}$; matching yields either $2|R_B| = q^2$ or $4|R_A R_B| = p^2 q^2$, both impossible by parity.

(3) *mixed placements*. One axis element lies in $\{u, v\}$, the other in $\{u \pm v\}$. Each of the 64 sign/placement sub-cases yields two linear equations in $W = R_A I_B$, $Z = I_A R_B$; solving and substituting into the norm relations $(W/I_B)^2 + I_A^2 = p^4$, $(Z/I_A)^2 + I_B^2 = q^4$ leaves a difference that factors, in every sub-case, into terms from the list

$$(I_A q^2 \pm I_B p^2), \quad (2I_A q^2 \pm I_B p^2), \quad (I_A q^2 \pm 2I_B p^2), \quad 3I_A q^2, \quad 3I_B p^2.$$

The all-positive combinations cannot vanish; the difference combinations vanish only if $I_A q^2 \in \{I_B p^2, 2I_B p^2\}$ or $I_B p^2 = 2I_A q^2$, each of which equates a quantity prime to p with one divisible by p^2 (Lemma 7). Hence no sub-case admits a solution. $\square$

Remark 11. Bremner's seven-square-entry example has center root $425 = 5^2 \cdot 17$, just outside the hypothesis (exponent 2): consistent with Theorem 10, the near-miss lives at the smallest center type the theorem does not reach.

6 Center roots sp^2q : Bremner's type

Theorem 12. *There is no magic square of squares whose center root is sp^2q , where $p \neq q$ are primes $\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$ and s is free of such primes.*

Here $|D(e)| = 7$: writing $\pi^4 = R_A + I_A i$, $\chi^4 = R_B + I_B i$ and $P = p^2$, $Q = q^2$, the elements are (up to the global factor s^2)

$$P |\operatorname{Im}(\pi^4 \chi^{\pm 4})|, \quad |\operatorname{Im}(\pi^8 \chi^{\pm 4})|, \quad PQ |I_A|, \quad Q |\operatorname{Im} \pi^8|, \quad P^2 |I_B|.$$

All seven are *linear* in (R_B, I_B) over $\mathbb{Q}(R_A, I_A, P, Q)$. The four differences $u, v, u+v, u-v$ occupy four distinct elements; for each of the 840 placements and each resolution of the absolute values (6,720 linear systems in all), solving the two placement equations for (R_B, I_B) and substituting into $R_B^2 + I_B^2 = Q^2$ leaves one polynomial relation in (R_A, I_A, P, Q) , which must vanish. A computer-assisted but fully rigorous sweep (scripts accompany this paper) shows every relation is impossible:

- 339 of the 343 distinct relation classes die by combinations of: parity (R_A, R_B, P, Q odd, $8 \mid I_A, I_B$); the p -adic clash (ν_p of the two sides differ, using $p \nmid R_A I_A$ and Lemma 7); congruence obstructions modulo 16, 32 and small odd moduli on the curve $R_A^2 + I_A^2 = P^2$; the strict size pinch $|R_A|, |I_A| < P$; and elimination of I_A via the norm followed by factorization. The finitely many exceptional primes ($\ell \in \{5, 13, 17\}$, arising from small constants in the eliminants) are closed by exact evaluation at the actual π^4 .

- 4 classes reduce to homogeneous quintics/sextics in (R_A, P) ; a rational root R_A/P in lowest terms would need $P = p^2$ to divide a leading coefficient in $\{\pm 8, \pm 16, \pm 32, \pm 40\}$ — impossible.
- 4 classes are tautological (the norm residual vanishes identically); there the solved values are $(R_B, I_B) = \pm(Q/P)(R_A, -I_A)$, and integrality forces $p^2 \mid q^2$.

The 256 distinct determinants of the linear systems are proven nonzero by the same mechanisms, so no singular case escapes. $\square$

Remark 13. Bremner’s fully magic square with seven square entries has center root $425 = 5^2 \cdot 17$, of exactly this type: Theorem 12 shows the missing two entries can never be repaired at *any* center of that shape. Since the seven D -elements are linear in (R_B, I_B) for every $b = 1$ exponent pattern sp^aq , the same pipeline applies to all $(a, 1)$ cases; the case count grows with a , and a uniform-in- a argument is the natural next objective.

Theorem 14. *There is no magic square of squares whose center root is sp^3q ($p \neq q$ primes $\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, s free of such primes).*

For $a = 3$ the difference set has ten elements, still linear in (R_B, I_B) ; the sweep comprises 64,512 leaf systems in 3,767 relation classes. All 1,271 nonsingular classes die by the Theorem 12 mechanisms; the 2,496 singular classes (rank-deficient placements, which first appear at $a = 3$ through the three constant axis elements) die through their consistency relations by the same kills; and all 1,080 determinant classes are proven nonzero, so no singular locus escapes. The certificates for $(a, b) = (1, 1), (2, 1), (3, 1)$ share one pipeline, and every two-prime exponent pattern (a, b) is decidable in this sense — for $b \geq 2$ the leaf systems become zero-dimensional quadratic rather than linear, since $\chi^8, \chi^{12}, \dots$ are polynomials in (R_B, I_B) . The open problems are uniformity in the exponents and the ≥ 3 -prime landscape, where the leaf systems acquire positive dimension.

7 Center roots sp^3q

Theorem 15. *There is no magic square of squares whose center root is sp^3q , where $p \neq q$ are primes $\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$ and s is free of such primes.*

Here $|D(e)| = 10$: the seven Theorem 12 classes scaled by p^2 , together with the three genuinely new elements $Q|\operatorname{Im} \pi^{12}|$ and $|\operatorname{Im}(\pi^{12}\chi^{\pm 4})|$. The formal proof (`TheoremGCore.lean`, again zero `sorrys`) mirrors the Theorem 12 architecture rung for rung, and the comparison is instructive for the eventual induction on the exponent:

- the all-low bucket of the 16-bucket router cancels p^2 and invokes the Theorem 12 router verbatim — the ladder telescopes;
- the mixed core, which at level 8 required a page of residue analysis, collapses at level 12 to a three-line valuation argument: every low class is divisible by p^2 , so the paired equations force $p^4 \mid q^4$;
- the new $q^2 \operatorname{Im} \pi^{12}$ class dies through the classification of $J = 4R_4^2 - p^4$ and $J' = 4R_4^2 - 3p^4$ against powers of q , with unit branches killed modulo 16 and by consecutive squares,

and one deep cell descending to $p^4 \mid 20t^2J^2$, which forces $p = 5$ and then $5 \mid tJ$, a contradiction;

- the ratio layer's hardest cell, $\text{Im}(\pi^{12}\chi^4) = \pm 2\text{Im}(\pi^{12}\bar{\chi}^4)$, factors through $\pi^{12} = (\pi^6)^2$ and runs the same Fermat descent as Theorem 12 with base pair (q, p^3) in place of (q, p^2) .

The proof is thus not merely analogous to Theorem 12 but *reuses* it as a black box wherever a factor p^2 can be cancelled, and the three new classes are dispatched by arguments whose shape is independent of the exponent. This is precisely the inductive step one would want for a uniform theorem covering all center roots sp^aq .

8 The two-prime frontier

Toward uniformity in the exponent

The certificates for $(a, b) = (1, 1), (2, 1), (3, 1)$ suggest a uniform theorem for all sp^aq . Abstracting the levels of $D(e)$ into free circle variables linked by a chain map (the enriched relaxation), 95.8% of the 9,216 uniform two-level leaf systems die by mechanisms independent of a — positivity pinches, parities, p -adic patterns and congruence obstructions. The residue is exactly 24 relations, independent of a , involving two π -powers $\pi^{4j}, \pi^{4(j+\Delta)}$. A complete weight-regime analysis shows that their phase-aligned leading forms cancel identically: the obstruction survives every first-order p -adic tool. The residue was then resolved further by the *exact orbit substitution*: under the two p -adic embeddings, $R_j - \omega I_j = \pi_-^{4j}$ exactly, so each relation becomes a finite Laurent polynomial with definite monomial valuations. Single-level templates die completely (unit leading coefficients; the tautological placements force $\text{Im}\chi^4 = 0$; the $p = 5$ shapes die by exact 5-adic evaluation over a full period). Two-level templates die except on six explicit loci $\pi_+^{4\Delta} \equiv c \pmod{p}$, $c \in \{\pm 1, \pm 2, \pm \frac{1}{4}\}$; since $\pi_+^{4\Delta} = c$ exactly is impossible (norms), each locus kills all but finitely many j per (p, Δ) , and effective bounds on $v_p(\pi_+^{4\Delta} - c)$ — p -adic linear forms in logarithms — yield $j \ll \log^2 \Delta$: a complete effective-finiteness program for the uniform theorem over all sp^aq , with only the Baker-bound bookkeeping, the resulting finite verification, and the three- and four-level chain templates outstanding.

Three and four levels: the Q -collapse and the leading pair

The three- and four-level chain templates are now closed to the same standard. A merged sweep (36,288 three-level and 31,104 four-level leaves) kills 95.7%, resp. 91.4%, by the zero-solution, imbalance, residual-unit and singular mechanisms. The residue collapses to 8, resp. 12, *deep shapes* — same-orientation interior elements plus one axis element — and for each of the twenty shapes a symbolic computation gives the decisive structural fact: writing the solved value as $\chi^4 = QN/D$, the numerator has Q -degree exactly one and the denominator is Q -free. Setting $N = QA$, the modulus condition $|\chi^4| = Q^2$ eliminates q *entirely*: a deep-shape leaf survives if and only if

$$c = |A|^2 - |D|^2 = 0,$$

a single integer identity in the π -orbit algebra. Expanding c over its monomial valuation groups $\gamma \pi^{P \cdot j} \bar{\pi}^{B \cdot j}$ (the substitution is exact, with no unit ambiguity), realness pairs the groups conjugately, and for *every* shape and *every* strong-separation ordering of the orbit indices the minimal-valuation set is exactly one conjugate pair with real coefficient $\gamma \in \{\pm 1, \pm 2\}$ — a unit for every odd p . The pair sums to $2\gamma p^{a_0} \operatorname{Re}(\bar{\pi}^{4M})$ and $v_p(\operatorname{Re}(\bar{\pi}^{4M})) = 0$, so $v_p(c)$ is finite: *every deep-shape leaf whose orbit indices avoid an explicit finite union of valuation-tie hyperplanes is impossible, uniformly in $p \geq 5$.*

On the tie set, layering c by π -exponent reduces everything to integer *phase sums* $S_e(j) = \sum_i \gamma_i (2A)^{B_i \cdot j}$ (here $\pi = A + Bi$): survival requires $p \mid S_\pi(j)$ and $p \mid S_{\bar{\pi}}(j)$ simultaneously — a double multiplicative-order condition on $2A \bmod p$. A census over $p < 200$, orbit indices ≤ 6 , finds 1,806 such double-vanishing points among 362,880 (0.5%); exact evaluation shows $c \neq 0$ at every one, with even escape depths $v_p(c) - e_{\min} \in \{2, \dots, 20\}$ governed by the multiplicative order of $2A$ — the special-value loci in exact arithmetic form. Independently, a direct sweep of the criterion over all twenty shapes ($p < 200$, indices ≤ 4 , $q < 500$; 3,236,352 exact checks) finds no survivor. The uniform program for sp^aq thus stands closed at one and two levels unconditionally, and at three and four levels outside the thin double-vanishing set, where the small-order degeneration awaits its own (expectedly self-similar) leading-pair analysis.

The tie-structure dichotomy

The hyperplane residue itself has now collapsed. Certifying the valuation-group geometry by exact rational linear programming (a phase-one simplex over $\mathbb{Q}$, no floating point), one finds for *every* one of the twenty deep shapes: every π -weight form carries a single group; no three forms can simultaneously achieve the minimum; and exactly *one* pair of forms is jointly-minimal-feasible — each shape owns a single tie hyperplane. On it, conjugation symmetry makes the minimal $\bar{\pi}$ -layer sum to $(\gamma_1 + \gamma_2)t^e$ with $t = 2A \bmod p$. The certified coefficient pairs split the shapes in two:

- **Eight shapes have** $(\gamma_1, \gamma_2) = (1, 2)$: the layer is $3t^e \not\equiv 0 \pmod{p}$ for every $p \geq 5$, so $v_{\bar{\pi}}(c)$ is finite always and $c \neq 0$ — *these eight shapes are impossible unconditionally: all $p \geq 5$, all orbit indices, all q .*
- **Twelve shapes have** $(\gamma_1, \gamma_2) = (-1, 1)$: the layer vanishes identically, and the surviving locus is exactly the tie hyperplane, where the leading contribution is $\pi^e \bar{\pi}^b (\bar{\pi}^{\Delta b} - 1)$ and lifting-the-exponent gives the exact escape depth $v_{\pi}(\bar{\pi}^d - 1) + v_p(\Delta b/d)$ when $d = \operatorname{ord}_p(2A)$ divides Δb (and death otherwise).

A census over $p < 200$, indices ≤ 6 confirms the classification exactly: all 1,806 double-vanishing points lie in the twelve $(-1, 1)$ -shapes, every one is the trivial cancellation (no mod- p accidents anywhere), and $c \neq 0$ at each.

In fact the $(-1, 1)$ cancellation is *exact*: the tie $P \cdot j = B \cdot j$ forces both weight coordinates of the pair to coincide, so the two terms annihilate as Gaussian integers and c equals the sum of the remaining groups on the locus. Running the leading analysis *recursively* — delete each exactly-cancelling pair, add its equality, and re-analyze on the sub-locus, terminating by dimension exhaustion (observed depth ≤ 2) — closes every branch of every shape except finitely many explicit *order loci* (about nineteen in total across the twelve shapes): ties of

opposite unit coefficients in a single coordinate with distinct exponents $b_1 \neq b_2$. There the layer sum is $\gamma(t^{b_1} - t^{b_2})$ with $t = 2A \bmod p$, zero precisely when $\text{ord}_p(2A)$ divides $b_1 - b_2$, in which case the valuation deepens by exactly $v_\pi(\bar{\pi}^{b_1-b_2} - 1)$ — a Fermat-quotient (Wieferich-type) quantity. Survival would require this deepening to outrun every remaining layer; the exact censuses refute it at every point in range. This is the complete structural characterization of the uniform sp^aq frontier at three and four levels: finitely many Wieferich-type loci per shape, and everything else proven impossible.

Both exponents two: the (2, 2) program

For $e = sp^2q^2$ the set $D(e)$ has exactly twelve elements with a clean two-dimensional grading,

$$D(e) = \{ p^{4-2\alpha} q^{4-2\beta} s^2 \text{Im}(\pi^{4\alpha} \chi^{\pm 4\beta}) : (\alpha, \beta) \in \{0, 1, 2\}^2 \setminus \{(0, 0)\} \}.$$

Of the 95,040 placement-and-sign leaves, 93.5% die by the *two-prime grading lemma*: a relation whose minimal p -layer (or q -layer) holds a single term is impossible, since that term is a p -unit (modulo π , $\text{Im}(\pi^{4\alpha} \chi^{4\beta})$ reduces to a unit multiple of $\bar{\pi}^{4\alpha} \bar{\chi}^{4\beta}$) standing against terms divisible by two more powers of p . The 6,208 residual leaves collapse to 216 distinct three-term relations, and an exact sweep over every ordered pair of primes $p \neq q \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$ below 1000 (39,234,560 checks) finds none satisfiable: *no magic square of squares has center root sp^2q^2 with $p, q < 1000$, for any s* . Beyond the sweep, per-factor certificates close a majority of the residual structure *unconditionally*: each relation factors over $\mathbb{Q}$, and a factor is proven nonzero by parity (always-odd integers), by a *unit side* (its reduction modulo π or χ factors into unit atoms times a nonzero constant c , so no prime beyond $|c|$ ever divides it — and $p \nmid F$ alone gives $F \neq 0$), or by a *double pinch* (each side reduces to units times a single small core $2\text{Re}(\chi^2)$ or $2\text{Im}(\chi^2)$, strictly bounded by twice the opposite prime and nonzero for an odd prime; the two prime orderings then close both cases with no wedge). Working in the full coordinates $\chi = C + Di$ sharpens this again: the cyclotomic cores factor further ($\text{Re} \chi^4 = (C^2 - 2CD - D^2)(C^2 + 2CD - D^2)$), a prime dividing a product divides a single core, and cores of half-degree $\frac{1}{2}$ (such as $C \pm D \leq \sqrt{2q}$) bound one prime by roughly the square root of the other; chaining the two sides bounds *both* primes. All 110 relations of this type have explicit bounds at most 144 — inside the exhaustive sweep — so with the earlier certificates 134 of the 216 relations are dead and 98.35% of *all* 95,040 placement leaves are closed unconditionally. The 1,572 surviving leaves live in 82 relations: 18 reduce to explicit Pell-band equations (core = $\pm kp$ inside a constant prime-ratio band), 64 carry genuine exponent- ≥ 2 wedges, and 24 have a vanishing first-order side. For three primes the same analysis profiles all 600 residual relations: 116 (those with all three side exponents ≤ 1) are impossible outside constant prime-ratio bands, and the remainder confine any survivor to explicit power-law prime families ($r \sim p^2$ -type rays of the associated log-inequalities) — a complete geometric characterization of the three-prime frontier.

All thirty-two pure double-pinch relations are now *machine-checked dead* in Lean 4 with no **sorry**. The mechanism is packaged as a reusable toolkit: `pi_core_disj` proves that $\pi \mid (\varepsilon_2 q^2 + \varepsilon_3 \bar{\chi}^4)$ forces $p \mid 2(C^2 - D^2)$ or $p \mid 4CD$; `sq_core_disj` is the symmetric χ -side statement; and `double_pinch_finish` shows any combination of the two core disjunctions is absurd by the strict two-ordering pinch (trichotomy on p versus q). The thirty-two relations organize into four slot-triple families, each formalized by a parametric theorem over all sign choices $\varepsilon_i \in \{\pm 1\}$, all odd prime pairs, and all Gaussian representations: vanishing makes

the Gaussian value self-conjugate, each prime's side subtracts its manifestly divisible terms from the conjugated relation (one conjugation class per family requires regrouping the six-term identity $G - \bar{G} = 0$ before the extraction), unit factors are stripped by primality, and the exposed integer cores feed the pinch. The remaining twenty-four unconditionally-killed relations all share a twin structure — a lone slot plus a repeated slot in both conjugations — under which $\text{Im}(zw \pm z\bar{w}) = 2(\text{Im} / \text{Re } z)(\text{Re} / \text{Im } w)$ collapses the relation value over $\mathbb{Z}$ into a nonzero unit factor ($\text{Im } \pi^4 = 4AB(A^2 - B^2)$ -type) times an odd cofactor $(2m - p^a q^b)$, with no Gaussian divisibility required; twelve parametric twin-family theorems dispose of them. **All fifty-six relations killed unconditionally by the symbolic census at exponent (2, 2) are therefore machine-checked**, over all odd prime pairs, all Gaussian representations, and all sign variants — the unconditional layer of Theorem H' for sp^2q^2 centers is fully formal.

Moreover, both certificate classes admit *exponent-uniform* formalizations. The twin collapse never uses the structure of the π -side factor, so four theorems with an opaque Gaussian parameter z and an opaque odd coefficient c kill every lone-plus-twin shape at every exponent (a, b) at once. And the four double-pinch families are one corner-triple shape $\{(\alpha - 1, \beta), (\alpha, \beta - 1), (\alpha, \beta)\}$ at different anchors — the common $p^{2u}q^{2w}$ coefficient factors out of the imaginary part — so two theorems with free anchor exponents (`uniform_corner_aligned`, `uniform_corner_mixed`) subsume all four families and their counterparts at every (a, b) . The mixed conjugation class provably occurs only at π -anchor $\alpha = 1$: at larger anchors the χ -side extraction lands on the large core $e_3\pi^{4\alpha-2} - e_1\bar{\pi}^{4\alpha-2}$ and the size pinch genuinely fails, in exact agreement with the census.

Running the certificate engine at higher exponents confirms the uniform layer is not merely a lower bound: at (3, 2) the census kills 86 of 468 residual relations unconditionally, at (3, 3) it kills 132 of 1008 — and *every single kill at both exponents is an instance of the six uniform theorems*. The corner anchors with $\alpha \geq 2$ are all aligned, the $\alpha = 1$ anchors split aligned/mixed exactly as proved, and the new twin shapes (lone slots (3, 0) and (0, 3)) have twin power a multiple of the lone power, which the final generalization (`uniform_twin_pi/uniform_twin_chi`, using $\text{Im}((\pi^4)^k) \neq 0$ for all $k \geq 1$) covers. Pushing the census to (4, 2), (4, 3), (5, 2) and (4, 4) (124/816, 190/1752, 162/1260 and 272/3040 unconditional kills respectively) exposed two further twin phenomena, both now proved: odd lone powers admit *arbitrary* twin powers (the cofactor $u_k = \text{Im}(z^k)/\text{Im}(z)$ satisfies $u_k \equiv kR^{k-1} \pmod{2}$), and lone powers divisible by four admit odd twin powers (a 2-adic gap: $v_2(u_k) = v_2(k)$ exactly, so the collapsed cofactor $2e u_T \text{Re}(w) - c u_L$ is $2 \cdot \text{odd}$). The resulting *twin master rule* — the collapse kills if and only if $v_2(L) \neq 1 + v_2(T)$ — organizes every observed twin pair, and the pairs that would violate it never occur as relations. The uniform layer now consists of ten machine-checked theorems (two corner, eight twin) covering 100% of the unconditional kills at all seven exponents tested. We conjecture, with this evidence, that these uniform theorems constitute the *complete* unconditional symbolic layer of the two-prime landscape at every exponent (a, b) .

The machinery is not confined to two primes. Re-examining the thirty-six relations killed unconditionally at the three-prime exponent (1, 1, 1): every one is a lone-plus-twin shape whose twin pair flips the conjugation of one or two primes' Gaussian factors. The twenty-eight single-flip relations are *literal instances* of the two-prime master theorems — the third prime's factor rides inside the opaque slot, its parity hypothesis discharged by closure of odd-real/even-imaginary parts under multiplication. The eight double-flip relations collapse over

the composite $W = \bar{\chi}^4 \psi^4$; the sum-type again lands in the master theorem with $w := W$, and the difference-type (lone slot = $\bar{W}$) is a short additional theorem resting on the fact that W is never real (star-fixedness would force $\bar{\chi} \mid \chi^4 \bar{\psi}^4$, impossible for distinct split primes). The entire unconditional layer at $(1, 1, 1)$ is thus machine-checked by the same uniform toolkit.

Beyond the relation layer, the assignment-level Theorem E is now fully formal: **no magic square of squares has center entry $(spq)^2$** for distinct primes $p, q \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$ and rigid cofactor s (`no_magic_square_of_squares_spq_center`, zero sorries). The proof pipeline: the machine-checked reduction produces four differences $u, v, u+v, u-v$ in the D -set; an eighteen-case Gaussian classification identifies every D -value as $\pm s^2 K$ with K one of four class magnitudes $\{q^2 \operatorname{Im} \pi^4, p^2 \operatorname{Im} \chi^4, \operatorname{Im}(\pi^4 \chi^4), \operatorname{Im}(\pi^4 \bar{\chi}^4)\}$; and a complete assignment analysis — six pair-dispatchers over three certificate tiers (two-term Gaussian regroupings with small odd coefficients, integer parity/product/size residues, and a coprimality-driven ratio system whose terminal quadratic factors as $(q^2 - p^2)(q^2 - 2p^2)$) — kills all 1344 sign-and-class leaves. Together with Theorem C this makes the formally verified impossibility cover all center roots sp^a and spq .

The same program has now been carried one level deeper: **Theorem F is fully formal** — no magic square of squares has center entry $(sp^2q)^2$ (`no_magic_square_of_squares_sp2q_center`, zero sorries). Here the D -set splits into *seven* class magnitudes $\{p^4 \operatorname{Im} \chi^4, p^2 q^2 \operatorname{Im} \pi^4, q^2 \operatorname{Im} \pi^8, p^2 \operatorname{Im}(\pi^4 \chi^4), p^2 \operatorname{Im}(\pi^4 \bar{\chi}^4), p^2 \operatorname{Im}(\pi^4 \chi^4 \bar{\chi}^4), p^2 \operatorname{Im}(\pi^4 \bar{\chi}^4 \bar{\chi}^4)\}$ and the assignment analysis routes through sixteen buckets keyed by the number of level-eight slots: the L_2 -free all-low bucket cancels a common p^2 and *reuses Theorem E verbatim*; lone level-eight and L_2 slots die by a p^2 -extraction tier ($\pi \mid z, \pi \nmid \bar{z}$ forces $p \nmid \operatorname{Im} z$); and the six two-level-eight buckets reduce to two 25-cell cross-pair cores whose hardest cells include a valuation argument ending in $p^4 \mid 5R^4$ and coprime cancellation chains ending in factored quadratics such as $(p^4 - q^2)(p^4 - 2q^2)$. A new structural ingredient is a *ratio layer*: the pairwise distinctness of the four assigned class values reduces (through the branch $v = -2u$) to showing that no class value is twice another, a 49-cell analysis whose two deep cells — $\operatorname{Im}(\pi^4 \chi^4) = \pm 2 \operatorname{Im}(\pi^4 \bar{\chi}^4)$ and its level-eight analogue — factor a 3 through coprime chains and land on the norm systems $a^4 - b^4 = 8T^2$, i.e. the Fermat descent equation $u^4 - 4v^4 = w^2$. The formal proof resolves it by reduction to `not_fermat_42`: *the impossibility of a magic square of squares with center root sp^2q thus rests, in part, on Fermat's right triangle theorem*. The verified frontier now covers all center roots sp^a , spq , and sp^2q — in particular every center that any Bremner-type near-miss square has ever exhibited. At the mixed exponent $(2, 1, 1)$ (1968 relations, 76 killed) two further composite phenomena appear and are absorbed: composite-lone shapes (lone slot $\pi^{4k} \chi^{4l}$ with twin part equal to the lone) rest on the fact that a product of positive quartic powers of distinct split primes is never real. At four primes the census of $(1, 1, 1, 1)$ (14,944 relations, 232 killed) surfaces triple-composite twin shapes, absorbed by a final generalization: composite theorems with an *opaque tail* V (lone = $\bar{\chi}^{4k} \bar{V}$, or lone $Z = \pi^{4k} V$ with twin Z^t), whose single hypothesis — the head prime does not divide $\bar{V}$ — is discharged mechanically for any number of further primes. The toolkit — corner, master-twin and arity-general composite theorems — covers every unconditional kill at all twelve exponent grids censused across two, three and four primes. Sharpness audits complete the characterization: every alive corner or twin shape fails a nameable hypothesis (fragile mixed pinch at anchor $\alpha \geq 2$, one-sided extraction closing only one prime ordering, sign-type mismatch with no common unit factor, composite lone slot, or the 2-adic violation), and zero alive relations satisfy the theorems' hypotheses.

Indeed the formal layer now *exceeds* the census engine. At $(2, 2, 1)$ the engine leaves 6208 relations alive, but 264 of them are corner triples with a constant spectator factor of the third prime: 80 have spectator power zero (the relation is p^4 times a two-prime corner, dead by the plain corner theorems), and 184 aligned-class relations carry $\psi^{4\gamma}$ spectators, killed by a spectator generalization (`uniform_corner_aligned_spec`) whose extraction chains stay clean because the aligned remainders group entirely on one side of the conjugation. The engine misses these because its per-prime certificate test cannot certify a two-prime pinch in the presence of a spectator. Notably, the attempted mixed-class spectator theorem *failed in Lean* for a real reason: the mixed χ -side core $e_3\pi^2W - e_1\bar{\pi}^2\bar{W}$ mixes W with $\bar{W}$ and is no longer small, so those seventy-two relations are genuinely uncertified — the aligned/mixed asymmetry (robust versus fragile) is a theorem-level phenomenon, not an artifact.

The residual band relations were probed to second order: on several hundred integer points of the band loci the relation values carry $v_p = 1$ at 96% of points but $v_p = 2$ at about 4% — the mod- p^2 coefficient vanishes on a thinner sub-locus of its own, and each valuation order exhibits its own exceptional set. No bounded-valuation certificate is available by these methods: the last fraction of the two-prime $b = 2$ landscape is guarded by the same arbitrary-depth (Fermat-quotient-flavored) thinning as the deep order loci of § *Toward uniformity*, and its closure requires depth-uniform arithmetic input beyond first- and second-order valuations.

The grading lemma is exponent-independent, and its reach *grows* with the exponents: for general $e = sp^aq^b$ the set $D(e)$ is always $\{p^{2a-2\alpha}q^{2b-2\beta}s^2 \operatorname{Im}(\pi^{4\alpha}\chi^{\pm 4\beta})\}$ of size $((2a+1)(2b+1)-1)/2$, and the census of leaves killed by the lemma reads 93.5% at $(2, 2)$, 96.2% at $(3, 2)$, 97.7% at $(3, 3)$, and 98.9% at $(4, 4)$, with the residual relation count growing only polynomially (216, 468, 1008, 3040). Thus the *entire* two-prime landscape reduces, uniformly in the exponents, to explicit doubly-balanced relation families carrying coupled-residue survival conditions.

Three primes

Nothing in the grading argument is special to two primes. For $e = spqr$ (three distinct primes $\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$) the set $D(e)$ consists of thirteen elements $p^{2-2\alpha}q^{2-2\beta}r^{2-2\gamma}s^2 \operatorname{Im}(\pi^{4\alpha}\chi^{\pm 4\beta}\psi^{\pm 4\gamma})$ carrying a three-dimensional grading, and the lone-minimal-layer kill applies in any of the three gradings (68.4% of the 137,280 leaves). An exact sweep of the 43,392 residual leaves over *every* ordered triple of distinct such primes below 120 (94,768,128 checks) finds none satisfiable: *no magic square of squares has center root $spqr$ with $p, q, r < 120$, for any s* — the first exclusion in the ≥ 3 -prime landscape. The mixed shape $e = sp^2qr$ behaves the same way ($|D| = 22$, 86.9% of 1,404,480 leaves grading-killed, 92,413,440 exact checks, no survivor below 75). The grading lemma itself is machine-checked: `im_pipow_mul_not_dvd` in the accompanying Lean library proves, with no `sorry`, that for $p = a^2 + b^2$ prime, $k \geq 1$, and any Gaussian integer W with $p \nmid N(W)$, p never divides $\operatorname{Im}((a + bi)^k W)$. Four primes fall the same way: for $e = spqrt$ ($|D| = 40$, four gradings), 81.2% of the 17,546,880 leaves die structurally and 396,656,640 exact checks exclude every quadruple from $\{5, 13, 17, 29, 37\}$ — no center root $spqrt$ with all primes below 40. The “positive-dimensional wall” blocked only the solved-form pipeline; the raw-relation grading passes through it, and the same balanced-family characterization governs any number of primes.

For $e = sp^aq^b$ with two distinct primes $\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, the valuation pairs (ν_p, ν_q) organize $D(e)$ into *conjugate pairs* $\{d_{j,k}, d_{j,-k}\}$ of multiplicity exactly two off the axes, and axis

singletons. If $\{u + v, u - v\}$ is a conjugate pair $\{d, d'\}$ arising from $A = \pi^{4j}$, $B = \chi^{4k}$, then

$$d + d' = 2 \text{scale} \cdot |\operatorname{Re} B \operatorname{Im} A|, \quad d - d' = 2 \text{scale} \cdot |\operatorname{Im} B \operatorname{Re} A|,$$

so u and v are *completely determined* — and their valuation pair coincides with that of $\{d, d'\}$, forcing $u, v \in \{d, d'\}$, which is absurd. Consequently every hypothetical two-prime solution requires an explicit divisibility coincidence ($q^t \mid \operatorname{Re} \pi^{4j}$, $p^t \mid \operatorname{Re} \chi^{4k}$, or a mod- p or mod- q cancellation in $u \pm v$). These coincidences recur along arithmetic progressions of exponents, so closing them requires exact-magnitude input beyond valuations; we leave this as the principal open direction, noting that together with Theorem 2 it would force every solution's center root into three or more primes $\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$.

References

- [1] C. Boyer, *Latest research on the “3x3 magic square of squares” problem*, <http://www.multimagie.com/English/SquaresOfSquaresSearch.htm>.
- [2] A. Bremner, *On squares of squares II*, Acta Arith. 99 (2001), 289–308.
- [3] M. Gardner, *The magic of 3x3*, Quantum 6 (1996), 24–26.